solutions can be constructed in different ways. Responses to political issues, such as communal violence, can flow from wider collective stories about the country's transition. In this sense they can reveal different forms of "common sense" about "democracy" — not only emphasizing that there are multiple ways of understanding "democracy" (or its equivalents in other languages), but also that each of these narratives may be "valid on its own terms" (van Eeten 2007, p. 254). My approach to this study was thus situated in an emerging stream of scholarship (Frechette 2007; Schaffer 2014; Walton 2013) exploring meanings of "democracy" around the world using interpretive (rather than survey-based) methodologies.

By highlighting the different ways of constructing political problems and solutions, a narrative approach is valuable in exploring what Gallie (1956) describes as "essentially contested concepts". These are concepts that "inevitably involve endless disputes about their proper uses on the part of their users" (Gallie 1956, p. 169). Or as Patent suggests, they are "concepts which by nature invite disagreement over their meaning" (2010, p. 205). For example, in describing democracy one may appeal to concepts of "freedom" or "rights", yet these are also impossible to conclusively define. As different local and international actors react to the rise of communal violence, they attach different meanings to the words "democracy" and "democratization".[3]

For Gallie (1956), the utility of "essential contestability" is that it can facilitate mutual understanding about polarizing ideas. By examining the different facets of essentially contested concepts, it might be possible to recognize that one's opponents in a contest may also have internally valid perspectives. In this sense, Gallie assumed that the contestation over meaning would lead to "mutual recognition" (1956, p. 172) between rival actors and "progressive competition" (1956, p. 189). There would be a mutual sharpening of arguments through dialogue. Gaining consensus about the appropriate use of the concept may not be possible but, as Gallie explains, "it may yet be possible to explain or show the rationality of a given individual's continued use … of the concept in question" (1956, p. 189). And importantly, he suggests that not recognizing the essentially contested nature of concepts can lead to the "the chronic human peril of underestimating the value of one's opponents' position" (Gallie 1956, p. 193).

Freeden (1996) builds on Gallie's ideas, suggesting that contestation